

READING THE LINES

palmistry

▼ The hand of fortune

This diagram of the zodiacal lines and mounds of the left hand was included in Eliphas Lévi's *The History of Magic* (1860) and originally comes from a text on palmistry written in 1649 by French occultist Jean Belot.

Also known as chiromancy, palmistry is an ancient form of divination that involves studying the lines and mounds on the palm of the hand. Readings are used to determine an individual's personality traits as well as to make predictions about their future.

Origins of palmistry

One of the earliest records of palmistry dates to around 2,500 years ago in India, where the practice is believed to have originated. From there it spread across Asia and into Europe, and in the medieval

period clerics collected many texts on the subject. For several centuries palmistry was used mainly by traveling fortune-tellers, until a revival began in 1839 with the publication of Frenchman Casimir d'Arpentigny's book *La Chiromanie*, which included the first systematic classification of hand types. In the late 1800s, palmistry surged in popularity with the work of Irish astrologer "Cheiro" (see below opposite), and in 1900, theologian William Benham attempted to give it a scientific footing with his book *The Laws of Scientific Hand Reading*.

Written in the hand

Typically, palm readers categorize hands into one of four personality types based on the elements: Earth, Air, Fire, and Water. The shape of a palm and the relative length of fingers determine which element is dominant: for example, a square palm and short fingers indicates an "Earth" personality (practical and grounded).

Each crease or line in the palm is associated with an aspect of character, and can be read according to the line's length, depth, or arc. There are three main lines: the "heart line" (running below the fingers) relating to the pattern of relationships; the "head line" (moving down across the hand) denoting wisdom or thirst for knowledge; and the "life line" (arcing down to the wrist) indicating health and vitality.

The various mounds and plains on the palm are believed to link to the astrological planetary signs, and their shapes and definition provide further information about a person's character. By studying the pattern of lines and mounds, palm readers hope to divine a person's future.

"Cheiro exposed my character to me with humiliating accuracy."

MARK TWAIN, RECORDED IN A NOTEBOOK, c. 1896

